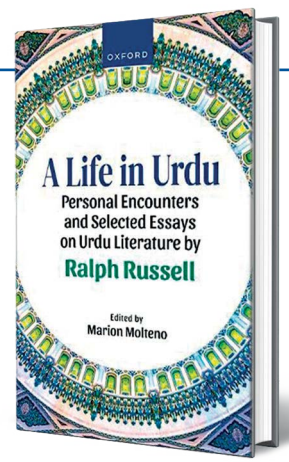
BOOKS

For the Love of Language

This collection of **Ralph Russell**'s essays is a reminder of the seminal role he played in rescuing Urdu scholarship from the burden of guilt



A LIFE IN URDU
Personal Encounters and Selected Essays on Urdu Literature
By Ralph Russell; edited by Marion Molteno
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Ralph Russell came to India as a young soldier during World War II. He knew no Indian language, but he realised very quickly that both in respect of his duties as an officer, and his engagement with the life of this strange country in which he found himself, he would have to learn a local language. I suppose we have sundry posting accidents—first to Allahabad, and then to various north Indian locations—to thank for the fact that he chose Urdu to escape from the prison of sahibhood. As it happens, Russell picked up enough Urdu competency to undertake an academic career in Urdu post-war. He was a crucial player in the formative years of Urdu at SOAS, and maintained lifelong, fondly-remembered connections with the seats of Urdu learning in India, with Aligarh and Hyderabad and Lucknow. Marion Molteno's volume is a worthy introduction to this rich and productive life.

Successive generations of Urdu scholars, and mere lovers of Urdu's rich literary tradition, owe an inestimable debt of gratitude to Russell for his 1987 essay, 'How Not to Write a History of Urdu Literature'. In this essay, Russell addressed the casual scorn with which the rich tradition of Urdu literature is regarded—the sighing lovers and the faded roses—not only by ignorant Westerners but also by "natives" who are under the thrall of European modernity. The specificity of Urdu literature is not addressed, but is evaluated in terms of a lack, a deficit of European virtues—that is, "nechar", a la Wordsworth et al, or "realism" a little later. Russell addressed this by taking on Urdu's founding literary historians, Azad—author of *Ab-i-Hayat*—and Hali, author of the *Muqaddima*. Although Azad and Hali are self-consciously pioneers of modernity, their work is subject to the operation of a profoundly paradoxical dialectic—performing "inferiority" in respect of the literary tradition that they are writing about, in relation to English models.

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In this essay, Russell does not go much beyond exhorting prospective historians to write about what is worth valuing in their tradition, but it is important to understand this phenomenon in some detail. For both Azad and Hali, the crucial experience was the upheaval, and the vicious repression, of 1857. Since it was "old India" that had risen up in revolt against them in 1857, the British were determined to extirpate every least sign of that "old India". The cultural im-